VAC-60 & Nutrition Program

A VAC-60 program, or a 60-day vaccination program for cattle, is essential for enhancing the health, welfare, and market value of livestock. By ensuring that calves receive critical vaccinations and deworming treatments approximately 60 days before they are sold or moved, producers can significantly reduce the risk of respiratory diseases and other common infections. This preventive care supports calves in building robust immune systems, making them less susceptible to disease during stressful transitions, such as weaning, transportation, and introduction into new herds. Healthier calves experience fewer setbacks, show better weight gain, and are more likely to thrive, which in turn increases their market appeal and overall productivity.

The return on investment (ROI) in a VAC-60 program can be substantial. Healthier, well-prepared cattle fetch higher prices because buyers recognize that they are less likely to face costly health issues down the line. Moreover, vaccinated and well-cared-for calves have lower morbidity and mortality rates, reducing the producer's overall veterinary expenses. For ranchers, the upfront costs associated with a VAC-60 program are offset by the enhanced growth performance and reduced risk of losses, making it a sound investment. Over time, implementing such a program can lead to increased profitability by boosting the reputation of the rancher as a reliable source of healthy, high-quality livestock—a factor that can foster long-term relationships with buyers and contribute to sustainable business growth.

VAC-60 Vaccination Protocol

A robust vaccination protocol is essential for a successful VAC-60 program, promoting health, preventing disease outbreaks, and optimizing growth. Here's a practical vaccination protocol covering essential vaccines and timing, which can be adjusted based on herd health history, local disease prevalence, and veterinary advice.

1. Core Vaccination Schedule

Category	Guideline
Injection Sites	Use the neck area, preferably on the side, to avoid damaging high-value meat cuts.
Needle Size - Subcutaneous	16–18 gauge, 0.5–1 inch.
Needle Size - Intramuscular	16–18 gauge, 1–1.5 inches.
Handling	Keep vaccines refrigerated until use, avoid direct sunlight exposure, mix only required amount per session, change needles frequently.

2. Optional Vaccinations (Based on Risk Factors)

These may be added based on region, herd history, and veterinary recommendations.

Vaccine	Purpose	Initial Dose Timing	Booster Timing	Administration Notes
Pinkeye Vaccine	Prevents pinkeye infections	Pre-summer or as needed	Annual, or as needed during peak pinkeye season	Ensure coverage during fly season for high-risk herds.
Anaplasmosis	Prevents anaplasmosis, especially in endemic areas	Day 0	Annual if given	Intramuscular injection in high-risk zones.
Calf Scours Vaccine	Prevents calf diarrhea caused by E. coli, rotavirus	Given to cows 3–6 weeks pre-calving	Annual, pre-calving	Given to pregnant cows to boost calf immunity.
Foot Rot	Protects against common bacterial foot infections	Day 0	As recommended by vet	Useful in wet conditions or if foot rot is recurrent.

3. Administration Guidelines

Category	Guideline
Injection Sites	Use the neck area, preferably on the side, to avoid damaging high-value meat cuts.
Needle Size - Subcutaneous	16–18 gauge, 0.5–1 inch.
Needle Size - Intramuscular	16–18 gauge, 1–1.5 inches.
Handling	Keep vaccines refrigerated until use, avoid direct sunlight exposure, mix only required amount per session, change needles frequently.

4. Record-Keeping

Keep detailed records of each animal's vaccinations, including:

Category	Details
Information to Record	Vaccine type, lot/batch number, date of administration, booster dates, any observed adverse reactions.
Signs of Adverse Reactions	Swelling at injection sites, respiratory distress, or lethargy.
Health Observations	Increased feed intake, minimal stress, and normal herd behavior.

Nutrition Program

Supplements and Additives

Supplement	Purpose	Dosage	Administration Notes
Vitamin E	Supports immune function	500-1000 IU/day	Include in mineral mix.
Trace Minerals (Zn, Cu, Se)	Boosts immunity, skin, and hoof health	Balanced blend in mineral block	Ensure free-choice availability.
Ionophores (e.g., monensin)	Improves feed efficiency and controls bloat	100-200 mg/hd/day	Administer in feed, avoid overdose.
Probiotics	Enhances gut health and nutrient absorption	Per product guidelines	Add to feed as recommended.

Feeding Schedule

Phase	Forage Feeding	Concentrate Feeding	Supplements
Pre-Vaccination	Free-choice hay or pasture.	Once per day with gradual increase to avoid digestive upset.	Free-choice mineral mix, include vitamin E.
Post-Vaccination	Gradual increase in concentrate with free-choice forage.	60:40 forage-to-concentrate ratio; monitor intake.	Free-choice minerals, protein supplement as needed.

Water Quality

Aspect	Description
Water Quality	Ensure cattle have continuous access to clean water, critical during vaccinations.
Water Testing	Test water quality periodically, especially in areas prone to seasonal contamination.

Monitoring & Adjustments

Metric	Target
Weight Gain and BCS	Target 2–3 lbs per day; BCS score of 5–6 by program end.
Feed Intake	Adjust feed amounts based on performance; monitor digestive health when increasing concentrate.

Health Monitoring and Assessment

Health Aspect	Purpose	Frequency	Target Indicators	Action if Deviated
Body Condition Score (BCS)	Evaluate body fat reserves and overall condition to adjust feeding if needed.	Every 2 weeks	BCS of 5–6 for ideal condition	Adjust feeding protocol based on BCS findings.
Weight Monitoring	Track growth rates and detect any issues with feed efficiency or health.	Every 2 weeks	Consistent weight gain; adjust diet if below target	Consult with a vet or nutritionist to adjust feed or investigate health issues.
Temperature Checks	Detect early signs of infection or illness by monitoring for fever.	Weekly, or as needed if illness is suspected	Normal range: 101.5–103.5°F	Seek veterinary advice if temperature is above normal.
Respiratory Rate	Identify respiratory issues, especially post-vaccination.	Weekly, or as needed if respiratory illness suspected	Normal range: 20–40 breaths per minute	Consult vet if respiratory rate is consistently above normal.
Fecal Checks	Check for parasite load and overall gut health.	Monthly, or as needed based on regional parasite risks	Minimal signs of parasite load	Administer parasite control if fecal tests indicate a high load.
Lameness and Hoof Health	Monitor for lameness or hoof issues to prevent mobility problems.	Monthly, or as needed for hoof care	Normal mobility, absence of limping or swelling	Trim hooves or treat infections as needed.
Appetite and Feed Intake	Ensure animals are eating well, which indicates health and reduced stress.	Daily	Consistent feed intake; reduction may indicate health issues	Investigate possible causes (health, stress) if appetite decreases.

Behavioral Observations	Observe for signs of distress, isolation, or other abnormal behaviors.	Daily	Normal social interactions; signs of isolation or distress should be flagged	Address environmental or social stressors; consult vet if behavior persists.

Parasite Control

Parasite Control Product	Type (Internal/External)	Initial Dose Timing	Booster/Re-treatment Timing	Recommended Product Rotation	Administration Notes
Internal Dewormer	Internal	Day 0 (start of program)	Every 60–90 days, or as recommended	Rotate classes of dewormers each season to prevent resistance.	Use oral or injectable dewormers based on vet recommendation; apply during low-stress times.
External Parasite Treatment (e.g., flies, ticks)	External	Day 0 (start of program)	Every 30–45 days, or as needed during peak parasite season	Rotate insecticides if resistance is observed.	Apply sprays, pour-ons, or ear tags as needed for external control.